UPFRONT

DIGITAL APPS: LEAVING ELDERS BEHIND *PG 14*

NARENDRA MODI: 25 YEARS OF REFORMS *PG 16*



CHECKING IN The UAE deputy PM inquires about the health of Captain Smit Machchhar, Abu Dhabi, Oct. 3; (inset) attacker Hamam al-Hammami

▶ FLYDUBAI ATTACK

HIDDEN ENEMY IN THE COCKPIT

The mid-air assault on an Indian captain by his co-pilot aboard a Flydubai flight has exposed a security vulnerability that aviation has struggled to address

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR & PRADIP R. SAGAR

THE CENTRAL PREMISE OF AVIATION SECURITY IS SIMPLE: keep anyone who should not be there away from the people flying the aircraft. September 11, 2001, transformed that premise into an elaborate security architecture—reinforced cockpit doors, tighter access controls, background checks and new crew-security protocols.

But what happens when the threat already has permission to be inside? That question has returned following the events aboard Flydubai flight FZ1073 from Dubai to Tel Aviv on September 30, 2026. Co-pilot Hamam al-Hammami allegedly used the cockpit's crash axe to attack Indian captain Smit Machchhar, in what UAE prosecutors call a "terrorist attack". "Had it not been for Capt. Machchhar's mental and physical strength, who opened the cockpit door while simultaneously thwarting the attacker and bleeding profusely, 174 lives would have perished along with the aircraft," says military and aviation analyst Arya Ghosh.

There were 174 passengers and eight crew aboard the Boeing 737 MAX 8. The aircraft can carry about 21 tonnes of jet fuel; had control been seized and the plane deliberately